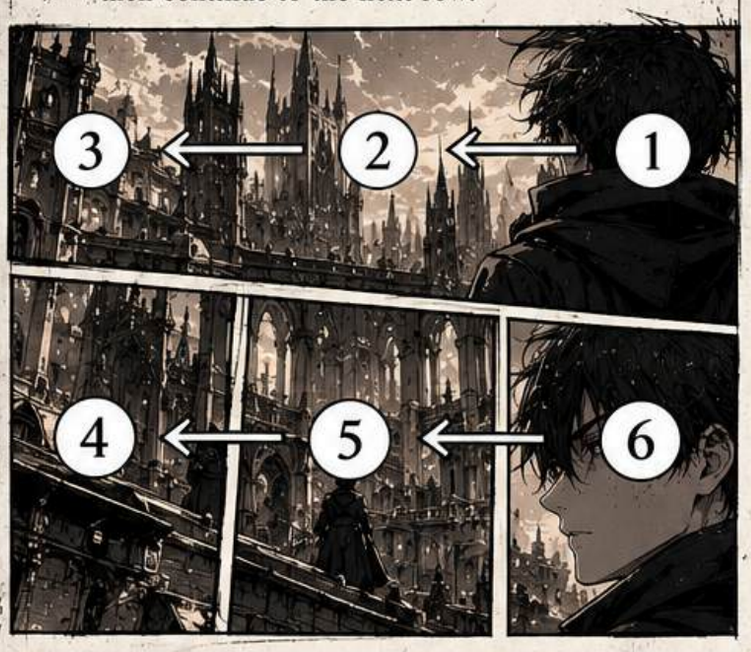

SOULSTAKER
A COMIC BY AARAV JHA

# HOW TO READ THIS MANGA

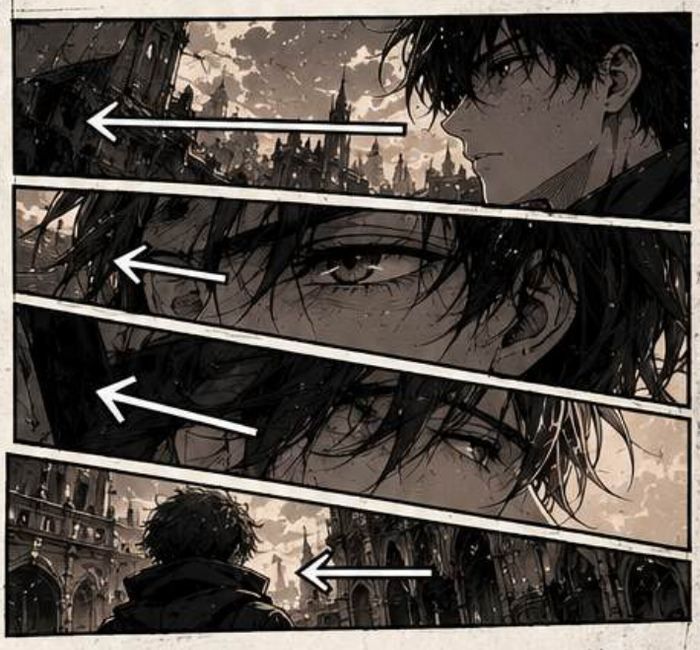
## 01 READ RIGHT TO LEFT

This manga follows the Japanese reading order. Start from the top-right panel and move to the left, then continue to the next row.




## 02 FOLLOW THE PANELS

Read each panel in the order of the arrows and flow. Sometimes panels are shaped differently to show time, focus or emotion.



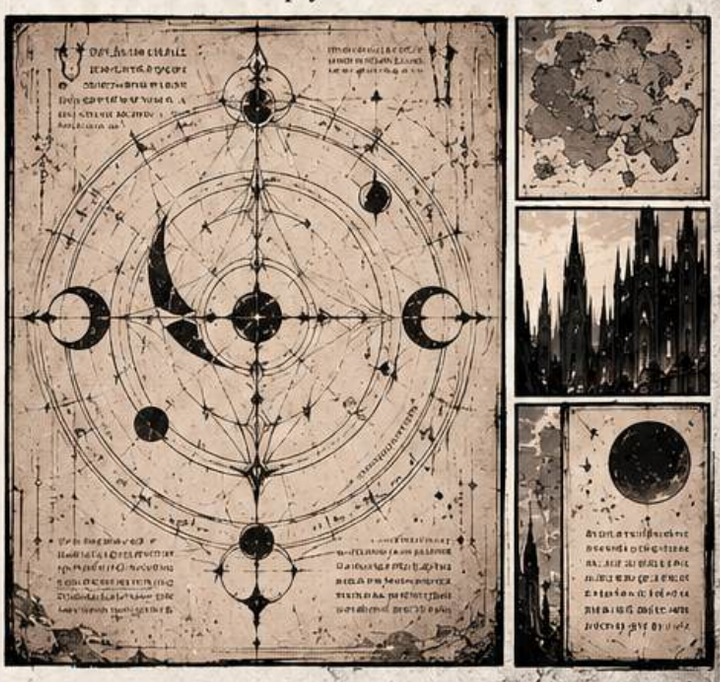
## 03 SPEECH BUBBLES & TEXT TYPES

Different text styles are used to show who is speaking and what kind of information it is.



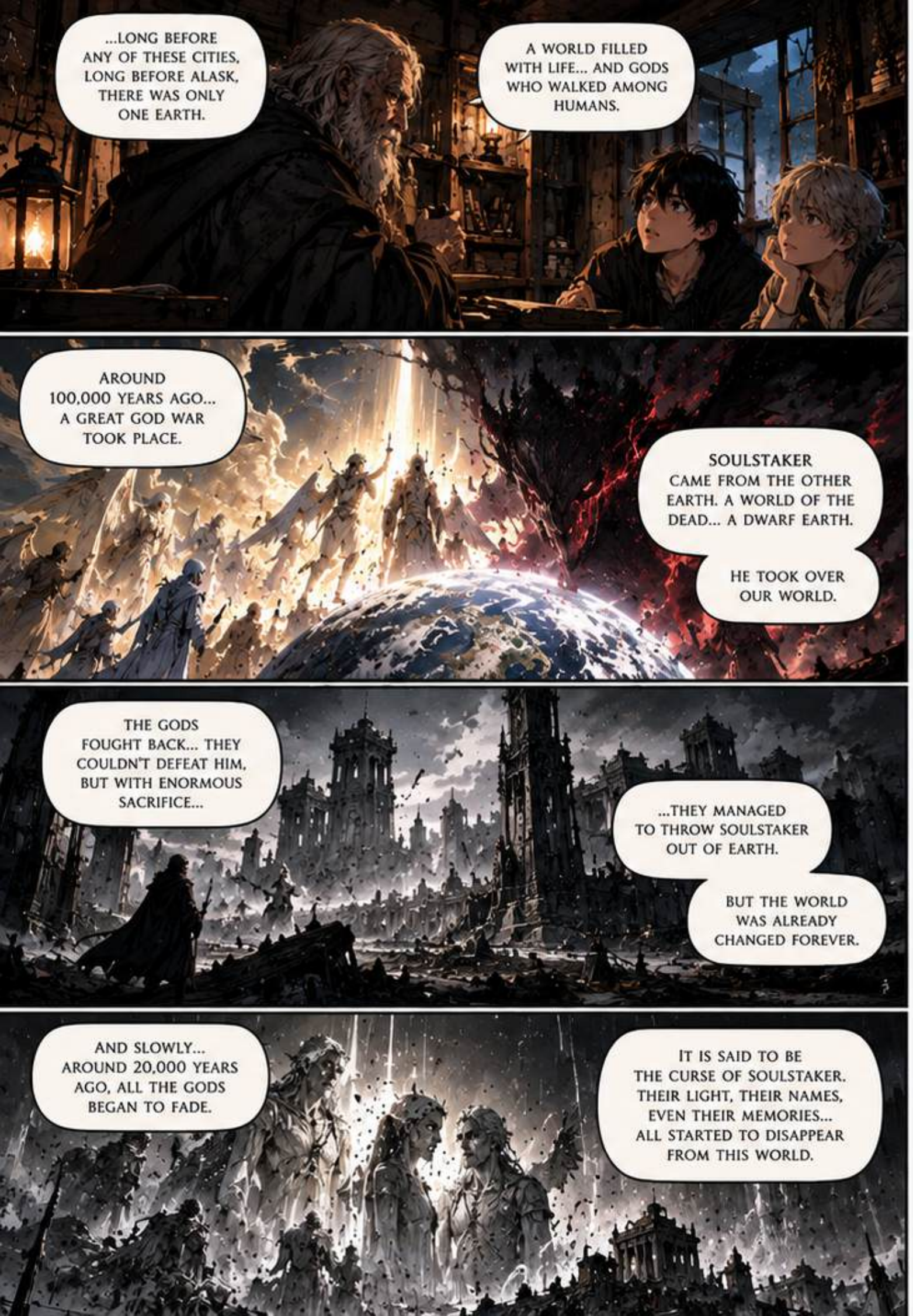

## 05 SYMBOLS & LORE PAGES

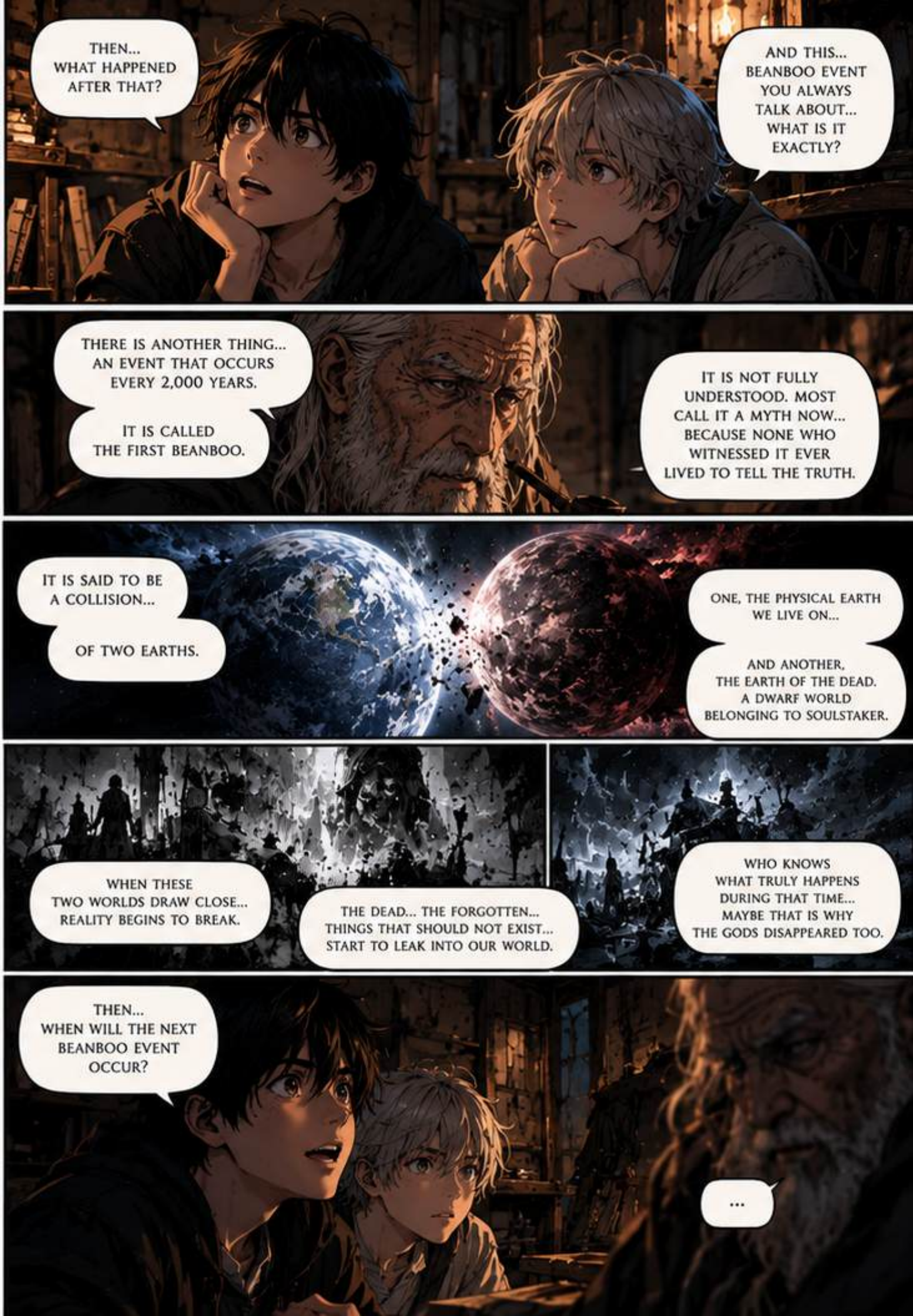
You will sometimes find pages with symbols, maps or explanations. These give world-building information and help you understand the story better.

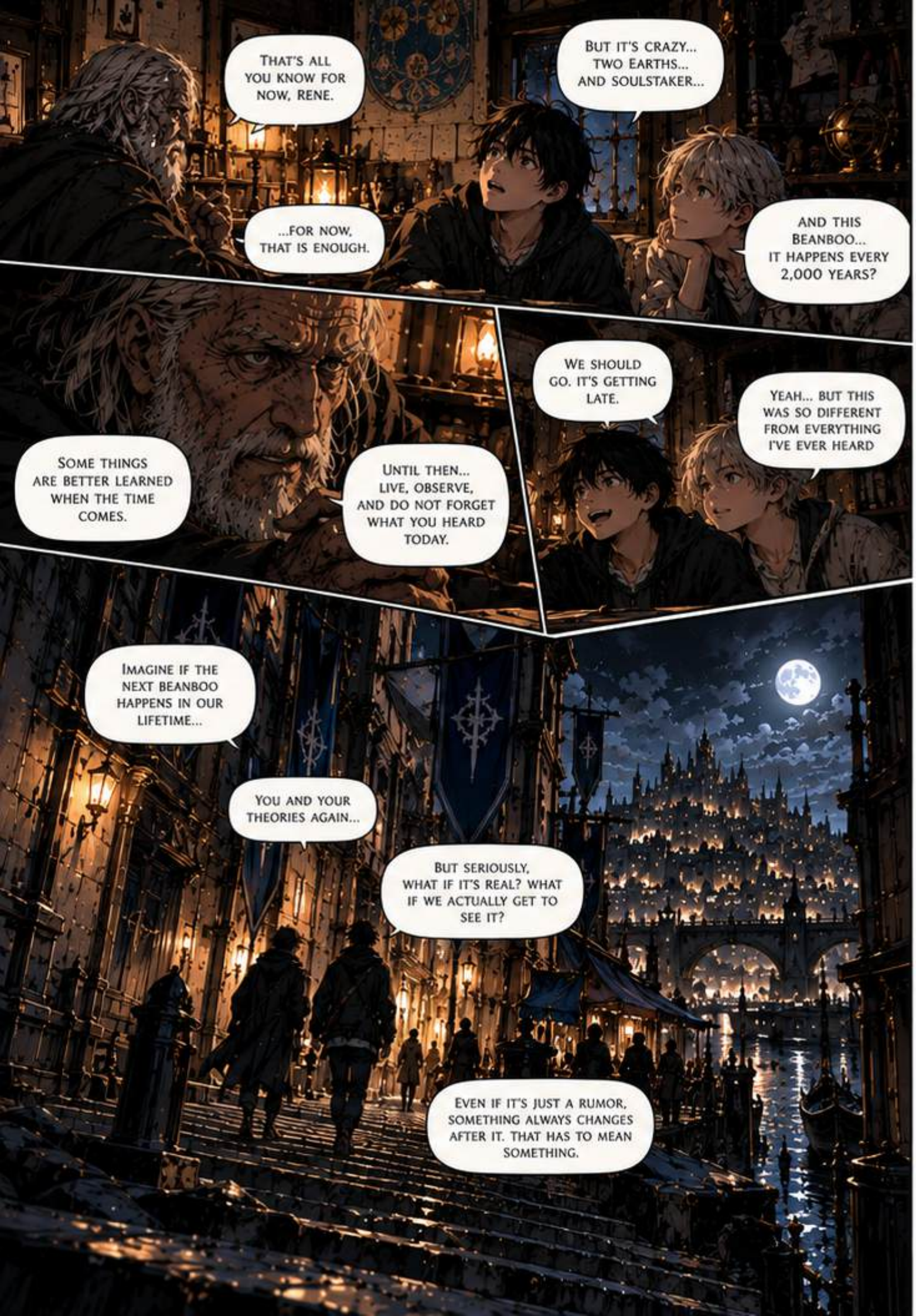


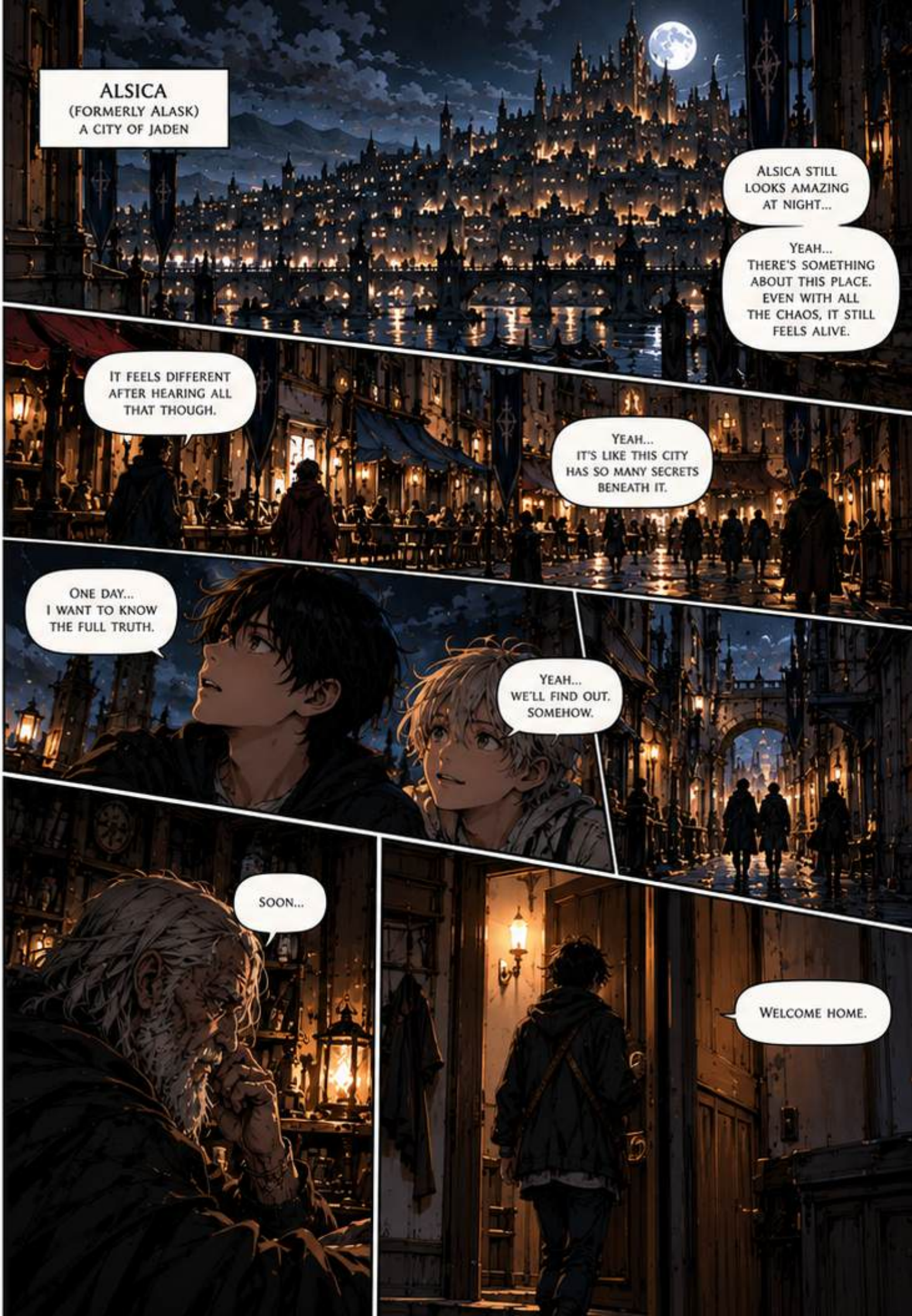

1999 YEARS AGO
ALASK
A CITY OF JADEN
...
...
...


19TH DECEMBER
PRESENT DAY
ALSICA
(FORMERLY ALASK)
A CITY OF JADEN


...LONG BEFORE ANY OF THESE CITIES, LONG BEFORE ALASK, THERE WAS ONLY ONE EARTH.
A WORLD FILLED WITH LIFE... AND GODS WHO WALKED AMONG HUMANS.
AROUND 100,000 YEARS AGO... A GREAT GOD WAR TOOK PLACE.
SOULSTAKER CAME FROM THE OTHER EARTH. A WORLD OF THE DEAD... A DWARF EARTH.
HE TOOK OVER OUR WORLD.
THE GODS FOUGHT BACK... THEY COULDN'T DEFEAT HIM, BUT WITH ENORMOUS SACRIFICE...
...THEY MANAGED TO THROW SOULSTAKER OUT OF EARTH.
BUT THE WORLD WAS ALREADY CHANGED FOREVER.
AND SLOWLY... AROUND 20,000 YEARS AGO, ALL THE GODS BEGAN TO FADE.
IT IS SAID TO BE THE CURSE OF SOULSTAKER. THEIR LIGHT, THEIR NAMES, EVEN THEIR MEMORIES... ALL STARTED TO DISAPPEAR FROM THIS WORLD.


THEN... WHAT HAPPENED AFTER THAT?
AND THIS... BEANBOO EVENT YOU ALWAYS TALK ABOUT... WHAT IS IT EXACTLY?
THERE IS ANOTHER THING... AN EVENT THAT OCCURS EVERY 2,000 YEARS.
IT IS CALLED THE FIRST BEANBOO.
IT IS NOT FULLY UNDERSTOOD. MOST CALL IT A MYTH NOW... BECAUSE NONE WHO WITNESSED IT EVER LIVED TO TELL THE TRUTH.
IT IS SAID TO BE A COLLISION...
OF TWO EARTHS.
ONE, THE PHYSICAL EARTH WE LIVE ON...
AND ANOTHER, THE EARTH OF THE DEAD. A DWARF WORLD BELONGING TO SOULSTAKER.
WHEN THESE TWO WORLDS DRAW CLOSE... REALITY BEGINS TO BREAK.
THE DEAD... THE FORGOTTEN... THINGS THAT SHOULD NOT EXIST... START TO LEAK INTO OUR WORLD.
WHO KNOWS WHAT TRULY HAPPENS DURING THAT TIME... MAYBE THAT IS WHY THE GODS DISAPPEARED TOO.
THEN... WHEN WILL THE NEXT BEANBOO EVENT OCCUR?
...


That's all you know for now, Rene.
But it's crazy... two Earths... and Soulstaker...
...for now, that is enough.
And this Beanboo... it happens every 2,000 years?
Some things are better learned when the time comes.
Until then... live, observe, and do not forget what you heard today.
We should go. It's getting late.
Yeah... but this was so different from everything I've ever heard
Imagine if the next Beanboo happens in our lifetime...
You and your theories again...
But seriously, what if it's real? What if we actually get to see it?
Even if it's just a rumor, something always changes after it. That has to mean something.


ALSICA
(FORMERLY ALASK)
A CITY OF JADEN
ALSICA STILL LOOKS AMAZING AT NIGHT...
YEAH... THERE'S SOMETHING ABOUT THIS PLACE. EVEN WITH ALL THE CHAOS, IT STILL FEELS ALIVE.
IT FEELS DIFFERENT AFTER HEARING ALL THAT THOUGH.
YEAH... IT'S LIKE THIS CITY HAS SO MANY SECRETS BENEATH IT.
ONE DAY... I WANT TO KNOW THE FULL TRUTH.
YEAH... WE'LL FIND OUT. SOMEHOW.
SOON...
WELCOME HOME.


ガチャ…
WELCOME HOME, RENE.
I'M HOME.
YOU'RE LATE AGAIN. HAVE YOU EATEN ANYTHING?
NO… I WAS WITH NAMOR.
HERE, EAT FIRST. YOU MUST BE HUNGRY.
HM… IT SMELLS GOOD.
TODAY… THE OLD MAN WAS TELLING US ABOUT SOULSTAKER… AND THE BEANBOO EVENT.
TWO EARTHS COLLIDING… THAT'S INSANE.
THERE ARE MANY THINGS IN THIS WORLD THAT WE NORMAL PEOPLE ONLY HEAR AS STORIES.
SOME OF THEM ARE BETTER LEFT AS STORIES.
MOM… WHEN WILL THE NEXT BEANBOO EVENT HAPPEN?
THE OLD MAN SAID IT HAPPENS EVERY 2,000 YEARS… IS THAT TRUE?
NO ONE KNOWS THE EXACT TIME, RENE.
THERE ARE ONLY RUMORS AND RECORDS… AND EVEN THOSE MAY NOT BE COMPLETE.

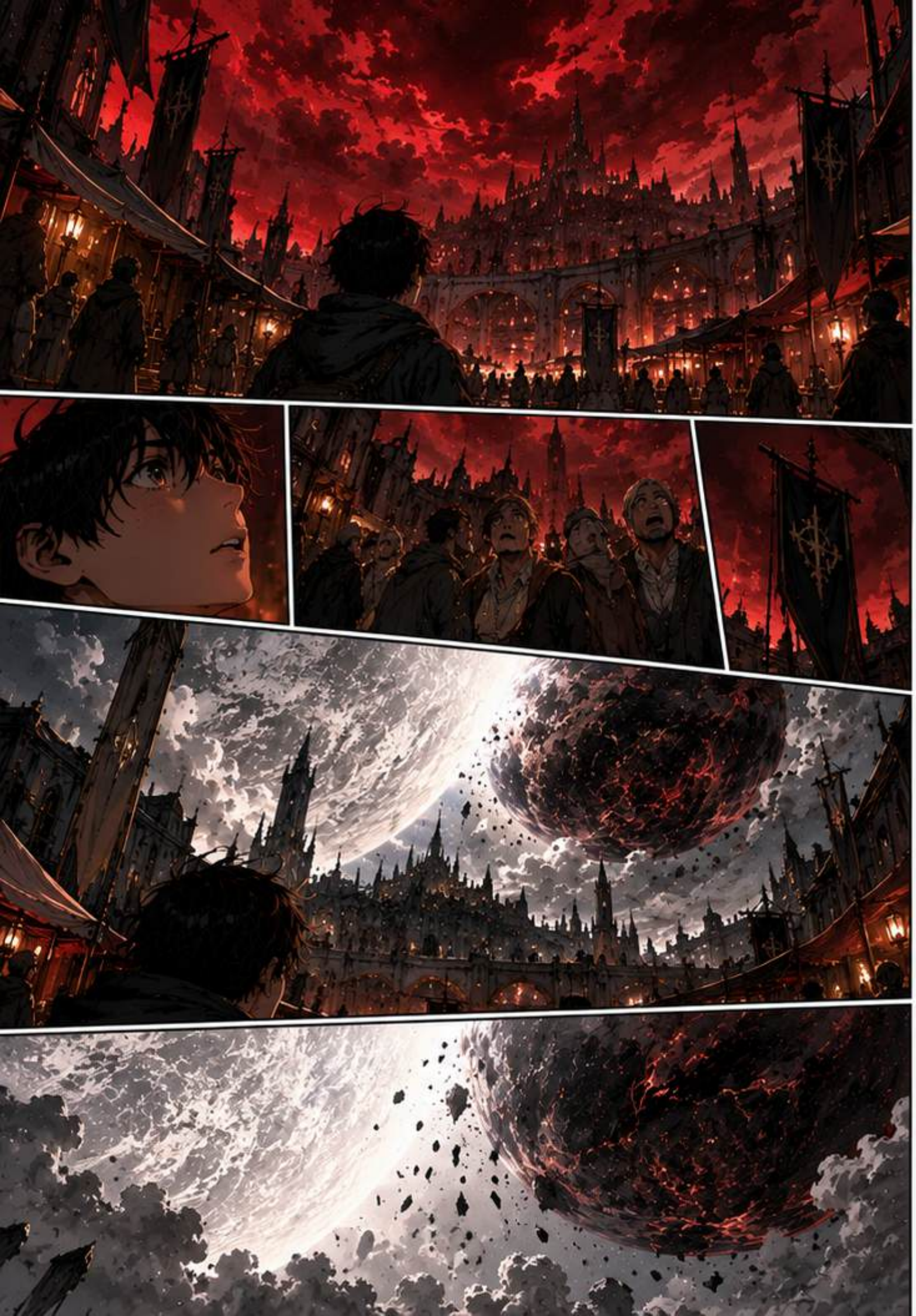

WILL IT HAPPEN IN OUR LIFETIME TOO?
DON'T OVERTHINK IT. FOCUS ON YOUR STUDIES AND YOUR LIFE.
THE WORLD IS MUCH BIGGER THAN THESE EVENTS, AND MOST PEOPLE LIVE WITHOUT EVER SEEING THEM.


DAD... WHEN WILL HE COME BACK?
HE'LL BE BACK SOON.
HIS WORK KEEPS HIM AWAY FOR A LONG TIME, BUT HE ALWAYS COMES BACK.

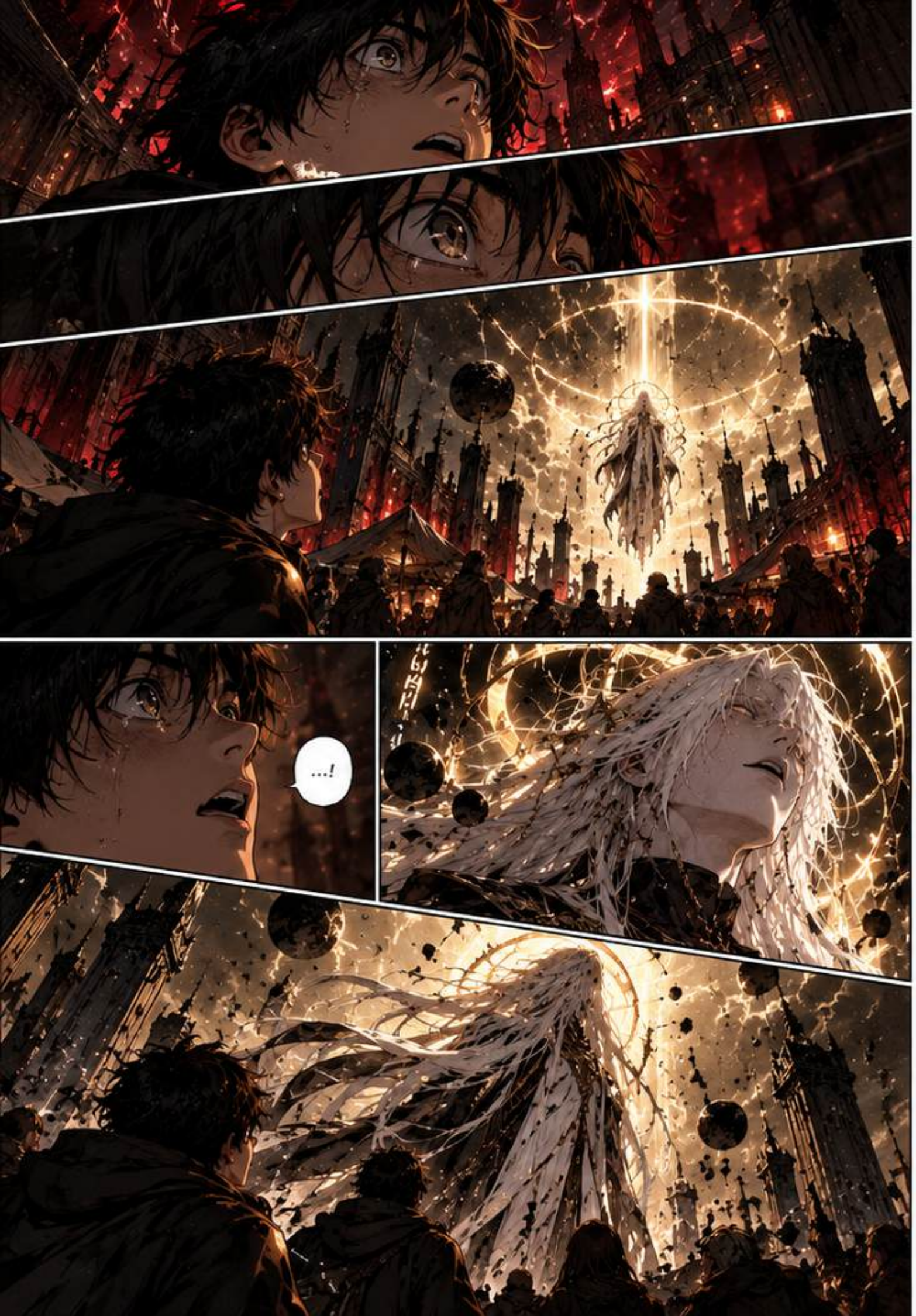

I HOPE SO...
I WANT TO TELL HIM ABOUT WHAT I HEARD TODAY.
YOU CAN TELL HIM WHEN HE RETURNS.
UNTIL THEN, GET SOME REST. IT'S LATE ALREADY.



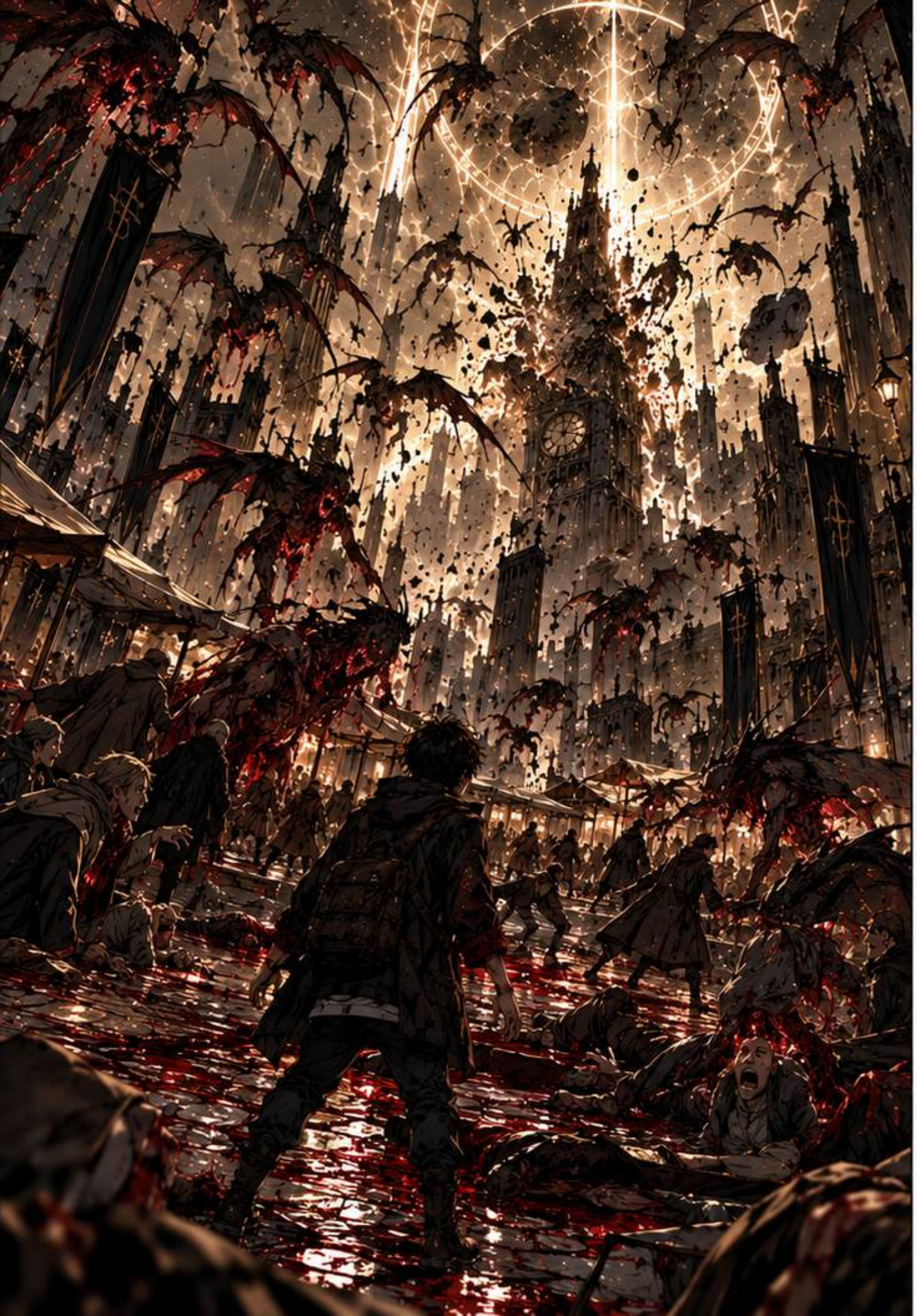

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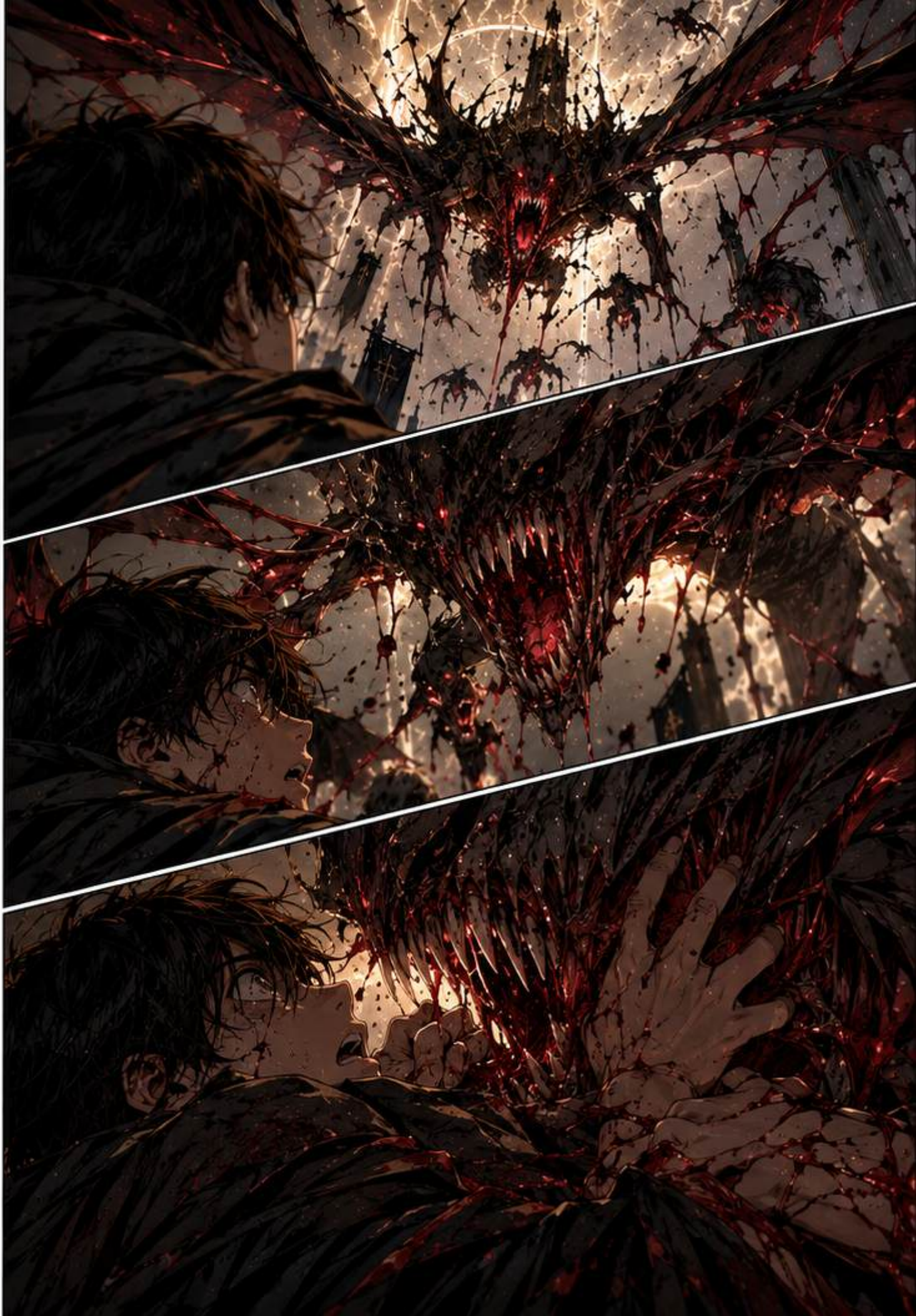







ZHAAR'KTHUL
VEXX'NAAR!!!!!





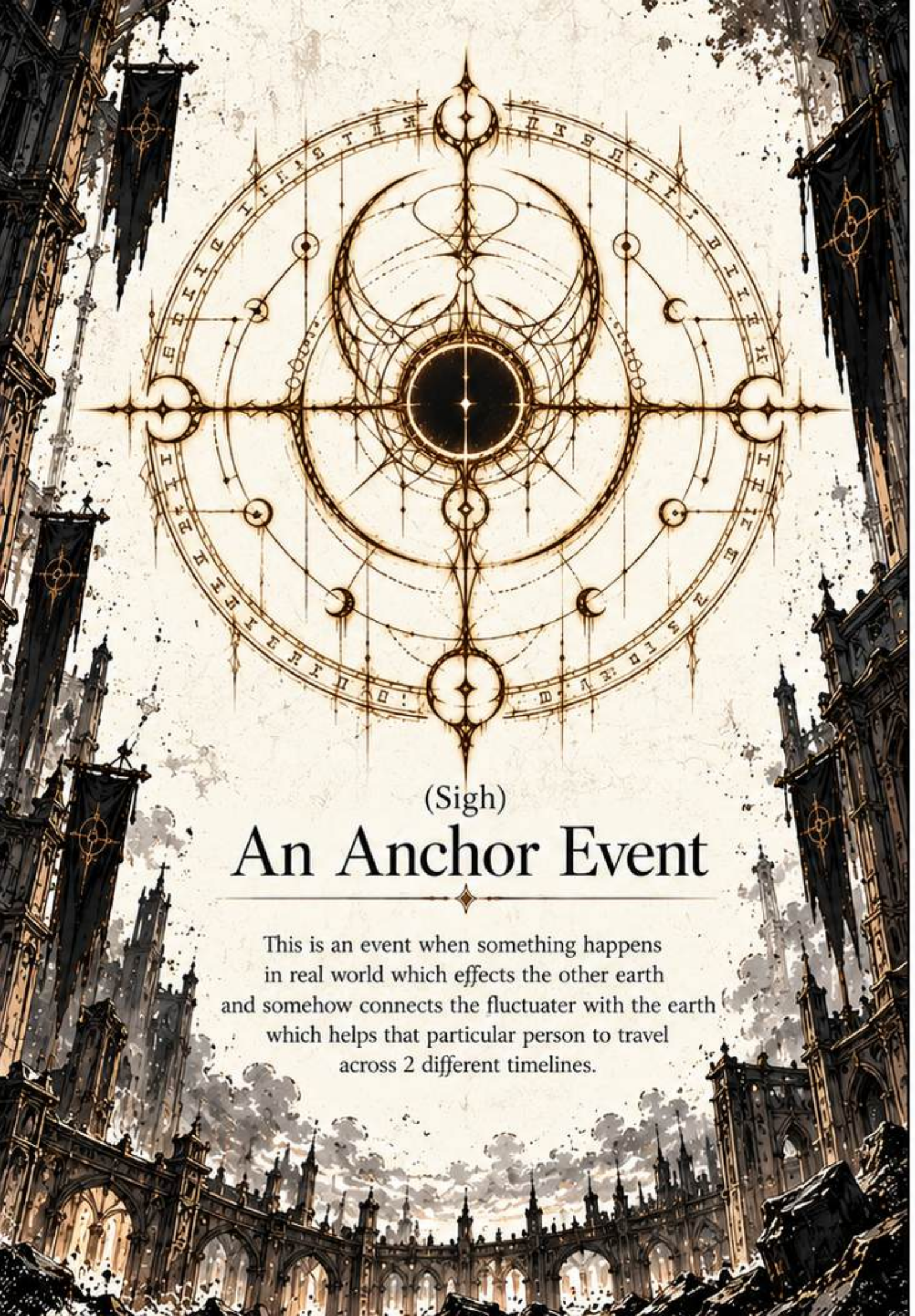

ハッ…!!
ハッ…
ハッ…
ハッ…
ハッ…
RENE...
RENE...
IT'S OKAY...
SHHH...
IT'S JUST A
NIGHTMARE...
YOU'RE SAFE...
I'M HERE...
I...
I SAW SOMETHING...
SOMETHING HORRIBLE...
IT'S OKAY...
JUST A BAD DREAM...
IT'S OVER NOW.
GET SOME REST.
I'LL STAY HERE
FOR A WHILE.


HE HAD ANOTHER NIGHTMARE TODAY... BUT THIS TIME IT WAS DIFFERENT.
HE WAS SHAKING... CRYING... I'VE NEVER SEEN HIM SO SCARED.


MAYBE IT'S BECAUSE OF WHAT THAT OLD MAN TOLD HIM YESTERDAY...
THOSE STORIES... THIS "BEANBOO"... AND THE THINGS HE SAID...
I DON'T KNOW, BUT IT FEELS LIKE IT AFFECTED HIM DEEPLY.


HE'S STILL YOUNG... HIS MIND MUST BE OVERTHINKING.
BUT... IT WASN'T JUST A NORMAL DREAM?
THE WAY HE DESCRIBED IT... IT FELT REAL TO HIM.


MAYBE WE SHOULD KEEP AN EYE ON HIM.
THOSE EVENTS... THAT HISTORY... IT'S NOT JUST A FAIRYTALE.
YEAH... WHETHER IT'S JUST HIS IMAGINATION OR SOMETHING MORE...
WE CAN'T IGNORE IT. LET'S SEE HOW HE IS TOMORROW.



(Sigh)

# An Anchor Event

This is an event when something happens
in real world which effects the other earth
and somehow connects the fluctuater with the earth
which helps that particular person to travel
across 2 different timelines.


About last night... I had this same dream again.
Tell me everything. Start from the beginning.
It always starts the same... I'm in Alsica... the sky turns red...
...then the moon vanishes and the world looks dead. Everything feels real...
Then that being appears... I'ne one with light around him... he screams something I don't understand...
After that... the clock tower breaks... and so many of those demon-like creatures come down.
They kill everyone... I just stand there... I can't move... Then one of them comes to me...
It gets closer... and I try to stop it... and then—
...I wake up screaming. It feels so real that even after waking up... my body is still shaking.
You've had this more than once?
...This isn't just a random nightmare, Rene. There's something more to it.

This isn't just a dream.

It feels too real... Too specific.

We should check it out.

This could be real.

Let's go to the old man's house.

...

I'm Alnino.

Why is that guy crying?

Ah...

N-Nothing serious...

I'm Namor.

This is Rene.

He just felt a bit unwell.

You may leave.

And thank you for your concern.

Who was he...?

He looked so similar to the one from your nightmare...

But he seemed human... And he knew you.

We should focus on the old man first.

Yeah. Let's just check on him.

OLD MAN'S HOUSE

KNOCK KNOCK

...It's open.

Something feels wrong...

What happened...?

Why is everyone crying...?

He passed away...

He was very old...

It was peaceful... in his sleep.

He was like a father to us...

He always took care of this neighbourhood...

We...

...we left our hat in his room.

May we look for it?

...His things are still there.

Yes... you may.

Please, go ahead.

Thank you.

Everyone is busy... we can go now.

Let's be quick.

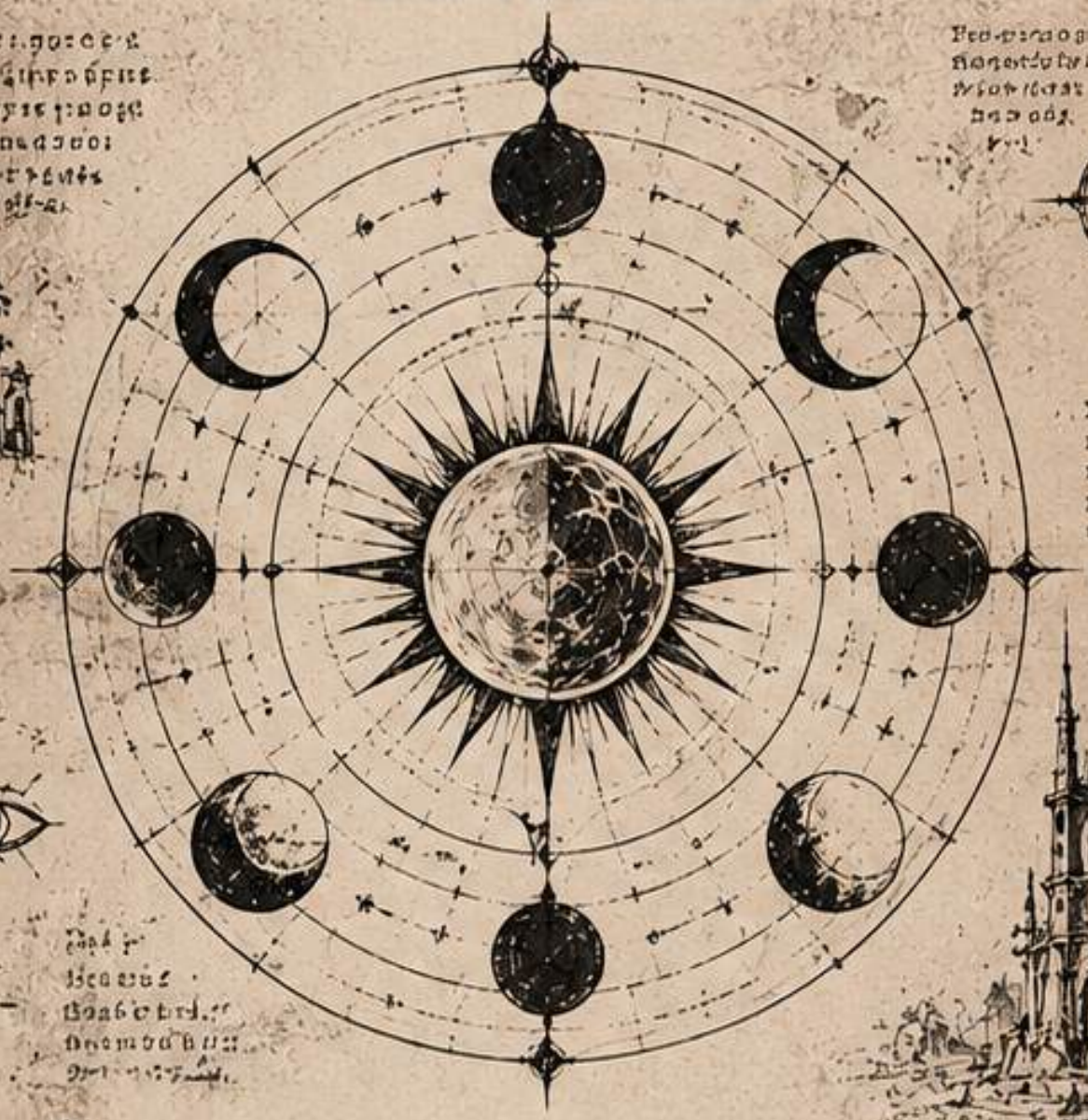
Here... so many books.

He really kept everything so carefully...

# 0

# WARNING

This book may contain spells, forbidden knowledge and information that can affect the mind, body and soul. Read it with caution.



⚠ Some contents may influence your thoughts, memories or dreams.

⚠ Certain spells can have real effects if performed incorrectly.

⚠ Do not attempt any ritual or spell without proper knowledge.

⚠ If you feel uneasy while reading, stop immediately and return later.

⚠ This book contains knowledge from different worlds and timelines. Not everything may be true in your world.

**PROCEED ONLY IF YOU UNDERSTAND THE RISK.**

# 1

# EFFECT

## BEFORE A COLLISION

Before a collision between worlds, certain changes begin to take place. These are called the Pre-Collision Effects. They appear in different forms and intensities depending on the distance, strength and nature of the incoming world.



### DEATHS

A sudden increase in unexplained deaths. People may die without clear cause, even if they are healthy. Sometimes entire areas are affected.



### CRUELTY

Emotions such as hatred, violence and madness intensify. People may become more cruel, committing acts they would never do normally. Societies can slowly break down.



### DREAMS

Many people begin to experience vivid and recurring dreams. These dreams can be visions of the other world, future events or beings related to the collision. Some may even gain fragments of knowledge.



### NATURAL CHANGES

The sky, moon or stars may appear different. Unusual weather, strange phenomena and changes in nature can occur. Sometimes gravity, time flow or the direction of objects may also behave abnormally.



### BEINGS

Creatures from the other world may start to appear. At first in small numbers, then more frequently. These beings can be seen by some people earlier than others.



### INSTABILITY

Objects, places and even memories can become unstable. Some things may appear and disappear, and certain areas may merge, overlap or change without explanation.

### NOTE

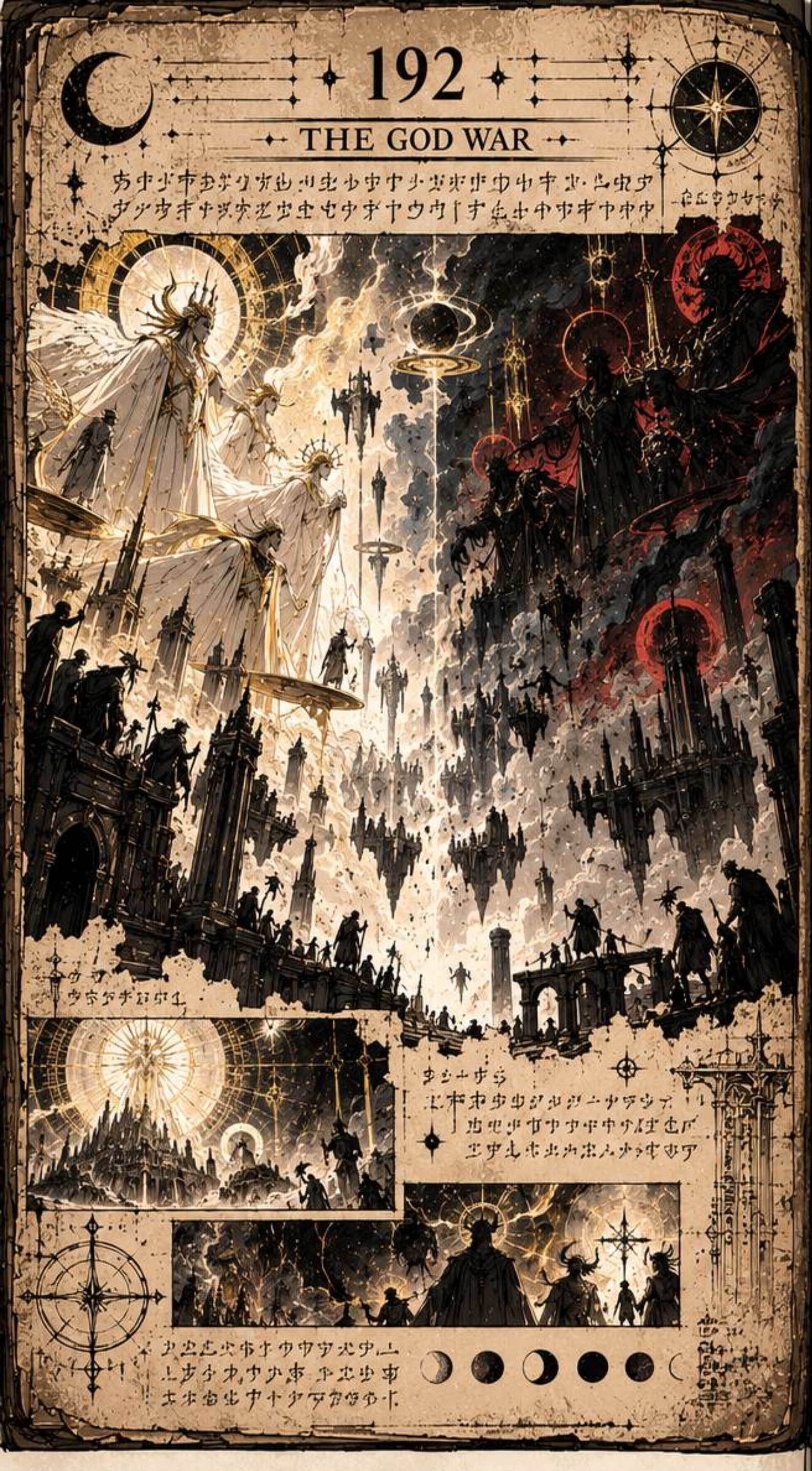
These effects are not always the same. They can be stronger or weaker depending on the worlds involved. In some cases, only a few signs appear. In other cases, all effects happen at once.

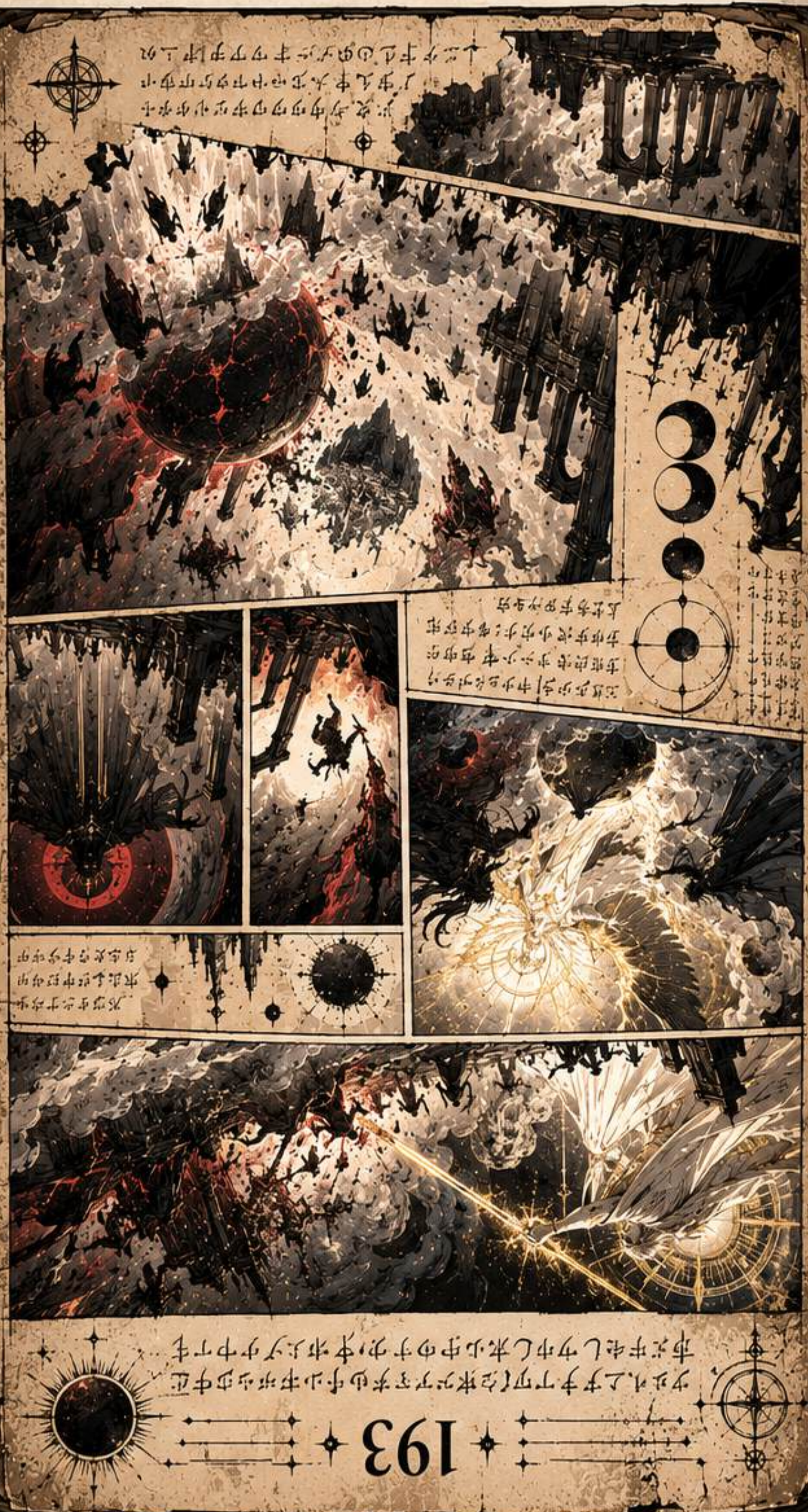




# 192

## THE GOD WAR





What is this...?

I can't understand any of this language...

These are not even normal words...

It looks like something from another world...

Skip to page 200. It contains the story of the first collision. Maybe we'll get some info.

200

200

—?!

Ah—!

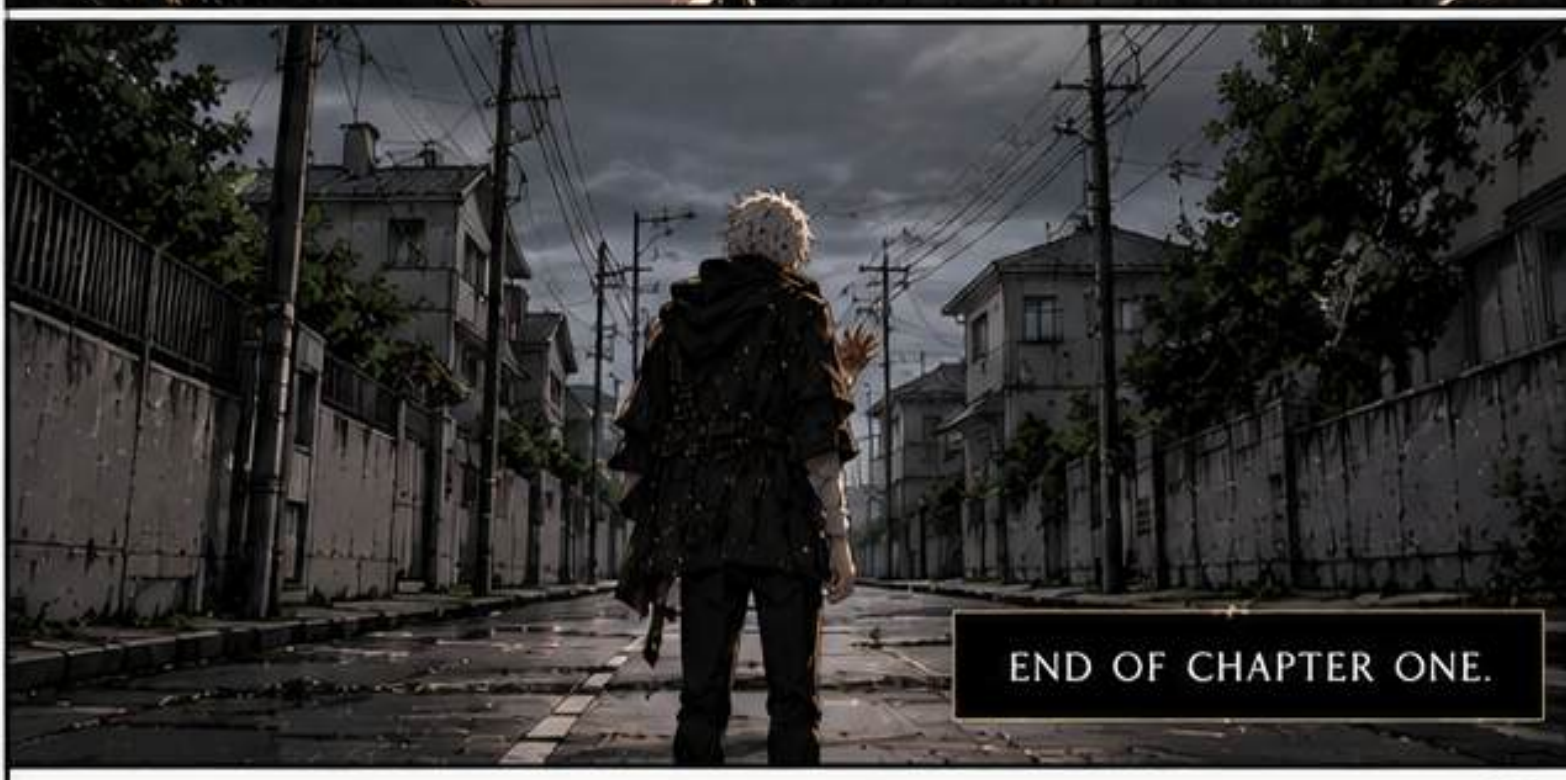
Namor!
Your hand—!

Get rid of it!
Now!




(YOU ARE COMING WITH ME.)


……?!


END OF CHAPTER ONE.